

Q. While YouTube has created a democratic space for people to express themselves, questions have also been raised about the credibility of some of the creators and the need for fact-checking. As a platform, how much control do you have over the content?
The magic of YouTube and the reason why I feel that the creator economy in India is so successful is because it is an open platform. It's like, as you say, the democratisation of content creation. Our mission statement is to give everyone a voice and show them the world. If you have something creative to say, an idea to share, you can do that on YouTube. But just because we're an open platform doesn't mean anything goes. We have always had community guidelines governing our content policies on YouTube and these have evolved as the context changes in the real world. Our principle is always an open platform, standing for freedom of speech and freedom of expression. But also having rules of the road that define what type of content is allowed. Striking that balance is really the essence of YouTube, and it's something that our teams think very deeply about.

Q. What about news organisations?
Alongside independent YouTubers who might also be either journalists or political commentators, that is really the sort of thriving ecosystem that exists. India Today, AajTak channels have had enormous success on our platform because they represent a brand and a commitment to the audience and the YouTube audience understands that and consumes them on YouTube. Everybody thinks of YouTube, of course, as something you consume on your phones, you open the app and you watch it. But our fastest-growing surface is the television screen, lots of news content, including your channels. And that's a big driver of growth for us as well.

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Q. In real terms, how do you ensure more responsibility toward due diligence?
The first thing I would say is that YouTube is fundamentally different from what you're describing. We're not a publisher, you're the publisher. We are the platform, the technology platform that enables publishers like you to be successful, find an audience, grow it, build trust and so on. So, that very fact-checking, that editorial process that you oversee and that drives news content on a daily basis is exactly what is applied on YouTube. But it's our publisher partners who are doing that. You're responsible for your content on YouTube, you take ownership of it, you can pull it down whenever you want. Of course, you're subject to our 'YouTube terms of service', our community guidelines.

Q. How do you formulate these guidelines?
We try to set those guidelines by taking advice from all our stakeholders, external stakeholders, and then we try to be very transparent about those guidelines, meaning that they are published on our website. The final thing is that we want to be as rigorous as possible in enforcing those guidelines. Because of the scale of YouTube—our corpus is 20 billion videos—the very large amount of content, we can't do all that manually. So, we use a combination of machine learning and artificial intelligence for content moderation. So, the machines can identify videos that may or may not be potentially violative of our content policies, then they get enqueued to be reviewed by highly trained individuals, many of whom are based here in India.

Q. How challenging is it to work with governments and policymakers when it comes to creators running into censorship?
We work on a regular basis with our stakeholders in government and, at the highest level, the interests are the same. The responsibility of elected leaders is